sessions. In the evenings we spent time in the pool or in the gym and soon all the players were looking forward to the tournament. No team had won the cup on home soil and it was our chance to make history.

## Group stages, February–March 1996

Our first match was against Kenya at Cuttack in Odisha in Eastern India on 18 February and we won the match comfortably. I scored a hundred and was Man of the Match. We then moved on to Gwalior in the west of the country to play the West Indies three days later, confident of sustaining the momentum. While February in the east of India can be nippy, in the west the temperatures can touch 30 degrees during the day. I had a fever the night before the West Indies game but still played and contributed 70 to our victory, which was set up by some fine bowling by Prabhakar and Kumble once again. Early on in my innings Courtney Browne, the West Indies wicketkeeper, dropped a skier at short square leg and I was able to make the most of my reprieve.

Having won our first two games, we played Australia in Mumbai on 27 February, determined to upstage the tournament favourites. Australia batted well and put up a competitive 258, riding on a brilliant innings from Mark Waugh, the younger of the Waugh twins, who scored 126. We did not begin the chase well and lost two early wickets to Damien Fleming, who bowled well throughout the tournament. That's when I tried to counter-attack, to get on top of Glenn McGrath and Fleming.

I managed to establish control and was going really well until the Australians gave the ball to Mark Waugh to have a go with his off-spin. I immediately picked up a couple of runs to square leg, followed by a sweep for four. As I'd hoped, the deep midwicket fielder was moved slightly towards square leg. Space at midwicket meant I could now go over the top for a boundary. Seeing me jump out, Mark Waugh bowled a wide ball. I couldn't reach it and was out stumped for 90. I have to admit I had been out-thought. It was a key moment in the game and we soon lost control amid a flurry of wickets. It was dispiriting to lose the match from a winning position.

## Looking after my interests

An odd thing happened during the break between innings in that Australia game. At the time, I was perhaps the only Indian player who